

RUNTIME STATE — PODCAST, EPISODE THREE

"The Slow Breach: Five Years of Cyber Incidents Inside South Africa's Government"

Target runtime: 20–23 minutes • Format: Solo-narrated investigative essay Voice direction: Same register as Episode One — measured, essayistic, sceptical but not cynical. This episode carries more evidentiary weight than Episode One, so the voice leans slightly more reportorial — closer to *The Daily* in parts, closer to *Slow Burn* in the analytical passages. Close-mic technique reserved for the diagnostic turns. The silences at the end of each incident dossier are load-bearing; do not fill them.

COLD OPEN — 00:00–00:30

[SOUND DESIGN — 00:00–00:03] Three seconds of clean studio room tone at -45dB. Same opening discipline as Episode One.

[NARRATION — close mic. Flat, low. Almost clinical.]

In August of 2022, the Federal Bureau of Investigation picked up a phone in Washington and called the Hawks in Pretoria.

[PAUSE — 1 beat]

They were phoning to say that someone was hacking the South African Reserve Bank.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

The Reserve Bank had not noticed.

[PAUSE — 3 seconds]

[SOUND DESIGN — 00:22–00:25] Runtime State brand tone enters — the same C minor pad from Episode One, 3 seconds.

[NARRATION — normal delivery distance.]

This is Runtime State. Episode three. The Slow Breach.

ACT I — THE ARGUMENT — 00:30–02:15

[NARRATION — settled, essayistic.]

Across the last five years, at least nine publicly confirmed cyber incidents have struck South African government entities. Justice. Logistics. Defence. Health. Weather. Labour statistics. Parliament itself. And the Reserve Bank.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

Read individually, each one looks like bad luck. A ransomware gang got lucky here. A contractor's laptop got compromised there. An annual report buried a paragraph about a breach from eighteen months ago. Bad luck, bad operations, bad timing.

[PAUSE — 1 beat]

Read together, they describe something else.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

[NARRATION — slightly sharper. This is the thesis.]

The argument of this episode is narrow. South African government cybersecurity is not failing at the point of attack. It is failing at the point of *disclosure*. The through-line across all nine

incidents is not a technical vulnerability — it is an institutional one. Departments disclose on their own timelines, in their own formats, to their own audiences. The Information Regulator acts after the fact. No coordinating body publishes a consolidated incident register. The public reassembles the picture by hand, eighteen months late.

[Half-beat]

That is not a resilience posture. That is a communications posture.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

Over the next twenty minutes, we will do three things. First, we will walk through the nine incidents — briefly, in order, so you have the timeline in your head. Second, we will look at what the incidents share: what makes a South African government entity a target, and why the attacks keep succeeding. And third, we will end on the disclosure problem — the reason you had to hear about most of these breaches from an annual report, a minister's speech, or a press release about a YouTube channel.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

[SOUND DESIGN — soft page-flip, -30dB]

ACT II — THE NINE INCIDENTS — 02:15-09:30

[NARRATION — reportorial register. Slightly brisker pace than Act I.]

Nine incidents. Five years. I will give each one roughly forty-five seconds — the name, the date, what happened, and how we found out. We will come back to the patterns afterwards.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

INCIDENT ONE — TRANSNET — 02:30-03:15

[SOUND DESIGN — single soft chime at -25dB marking the start of each dossier. Same chime throughout the act.]

July 2021. Transnet.

A ransomware attack against Transnet SOC Ltd — the state-owned logistics company that runs the country's ports and freight rail — brought operations to a halt at Durban, Cape Town, and Gqeberha. Three ports. One of them the busiest container terminal in sub-Saharan Africa. The company declared force majeure. Cargo backed up for days. Exporters paid the cost.

[Half-beat]

The group believed responsible was never officially named. Transnet released an internal advisory and resumed manual operations. A year later, the Auditor-General's report mentioned the incident in passing.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

INCIDENT TWO — DEPARTMENT OF JUSTICE — 03:15-04:00

[Chime]

September 2021. Department of Justice and Constitutional Development.

Two months after Transnet. A ransomware attack encrypted the Department's information systems. Court processes stalled. Bail applications delayed. Child maintenance payments — which flow through the Department's payment system — interrupted for weeks. The

Department confirmed the breach but did not name the attacker, and has never published a full post-incident report.

[Half-beat]

Among the people hit hardest: single mothers waiting for maintenance transfers. An abstract cyber incident, a concrete cost to the people with the least.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

INCIDENT THREE — SARB — 04:00-05:00

[Chime]

August 2022. The South African Reserve Bank.

The incident this episode opened with. The FBI phoned the Hawks to warn that someone was actively attempting to breach SARB's systems. The Reserve Bank's own monitoring had not detected it. Finance Minister Enoch Godongwana later revealed the detection gap publicly.

[PAUSE — 1 beat]

SARB maintains the attempt did not succeed. That claim is probably true. But the story that matters is not whether the attack succeeded. The story is that a foreign agency — the FBI, operating out of Washington — noticed an intrusion against the central bank of a sovereign African state before the State Security Agency, the Hawks, or the Reserve Bank itself did.

[Half-beat]

[NARRATION — CLOSE MIC.]

That is a detection failure at the level of national sovereignty.

[PAUSE — 3 seconds]

INCIDENT FOUR — SANDF — 05:00-05:40

[Chime]

September 2023. The South African National Defence Force.

A data leak, reportedly by a ransomware group, posted what it claimed was classified SANDF material online. The SANDF denied the scope of the leak. External reviewers — including defence-intelligence analysts outside the country — did not find the denial fully persuasive. Some of the leaked documents appeared authentic on their face.

[Half-beat]

The public record on this incident is thin, because the SANDF has not released a post-incident technical summary and is not required to.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

INCIDENT FIVE — NHLS — 05:40-06:25

[Chime]

June 2024. The National Health Laboratory Service.

A ransomware attack that mattered in a way most of these attacks do not: it stopped surgeries. NHLS runs the laboratory infrastructure for the entire public health system — blood work, pathology, diagnostic confirmation. When it went down, hospitals could not confirm diagnoses,

could not cross-match blood, could not clear patients for theatre. Non-urgent surgeries were cancelled across multiple provinces.

[PAUSE — 1 beat]

The public only learned the full operational impact when NHLS mentioned the incident in its 2023-24 annual report, roughly a year after the attack.

[Half-beat]

A year. For a breach that stopped surgeries.

[PAUSE — 3 seconds]

INCIDENT SIX — DPWI — 06:25-07:05

[Chime]

2024. The Department of Public Works and Infrastructure.

The public learned of this breach in the most South African way imaginable: the Minister mentioned it in a speech. No press release. No formal disclosure. No incident report. The Minister, speaking to a stakeholder forum, referenced a cyber incident that had disrupted the Department's systems. Journalists picked it up from the transcript.

[Half-beat]

We still do not know the attacker, the vector, or the full scope.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

INCIDENT SEVEN — SAWS — 07:05-07:45

[Chime]

2024. The South African Weather Service.

A cyber incident took the Weather Service's public-facing systems offline. Aviation weather feeds, disrupted. Agricultural forecasting, disrupted. Public weather services, degraded for an extended period. SAWS recovered and published a technical statement — one of the more forthcoming disclosures in the set, though still after the fact.

[Half-beat]

Weather forecasting is not a luxury service. Farmers and pilots plan around it.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

INCIDENT EIGHT — PARLIAMENT — 07:45-08:30

[Chime]

March 2025. The Parliament of South Africa.

One of Parliament's YouTube streaming services was compromised and used, briefly, to broadcast unrelated content to viewers expecting legislative proceedings. Parliament issued a press release framing the incident as narrow — *one of twenty-five channels*, the statement emphasised. Which was technically true, and completely beside the point.

[PAUSE — 1 beat]

[NARRATION — CLOSE MIC.]

The legislature was breached. The public learned about it through a press release about a YouTube channel.

[Half-beat]

That is not a resilience posture. That is a communications posture.

[PAUSE — 3 seconds]

INCIDENT NINE — STATS SA — 08:30-09:15

[Chime]

2025 into 2026. Statistics South Africa.

The most recent confirmed incident. Reports — disputed by Stats SA management, confirmed by some of the affected unions — indicate a breach that compromised HR pipelines and some internal data systems. Stats SA insists core statistical production systems were untouched. The unions dispute the scope of the denial.

[Half-beat]

The reason this matters beyond Stats SA: the institution produces the numbers the country uses to measure itself. Unemployment. Inflation. Census data. The credibility of Stats SA's data is a public good, and public goods depend on public trust, and public trust depends on disclosure that is faster than a union dispute.

[PAUSE — 3 seconds]

[SOUND DESIGN — chime fades. Page-flip at -30dB.]

ACT III — THE PATTERNS — 09:30-13:30

[NARRATION — analytical register.]

Nine incidents. Let me show you what they share.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

PATTERN ONE — OPERATIONAL DISRUPTION, NOT JUST DATA THEFT

Five of the nine incidents did more than steal data. They stopped services. Ports closed. Courts stalled. Hospital surgeries cancelled. Weather forecasts degraded. HR pipelines frozen.

[Half-beat]

This is the first thing worth understanding. Cyber risk in South Africa is no longer about data privacy in any narrow sense. It is now indistinguishable from service-delivery risk. When the National Health Laboratory Service goes down, people do not get surgeries. When Transnet goes down, exporters do not ship. When the Department of Justice goes down, single mothers do not receive maintenance.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

[NARRATION — CLOSE MIC.]

The question of whether the state can keep its own lights on has merged with the question of whether the state can deliver.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

PATTERN TWO — THE DISCLOSURE LAG

Six to eighteen months. That is the typical gap between compromise and public acknowledgment across these nine incidents.

[Half-beat]

NHLS surfaced via an annual report. DPWI surfaced via a minister's speech. SANDF surfaced via leaked documents on a ransomware gang's blog. Stats SA surfaced via union disputes. Parliament surfaced via a press release about a YouTube channel. SARB surfaced via the FBI.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

In every case, the disclosure came from somewhere other than a structured, timely, public incident report issued by the affected institution. In most cases, the disclosure came from outside the institution entirely.

[PAUSE — 1 beat]

This is the gap where accountability quietly disappears. If the public learns about a breach eighteen months after the fact, it cannot meaningfully demand consequences. By the time the incident surfaces, the leadership has rotated, the budget cycle has closed, the news cycle has moved, and the institutional memory has thinned to the point of uselessness. The breach becomes a footnote in the next annual report.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

PATTERN THREE — NO UNIFIED RESPONSE

And here is the structural finding. Zero coordinating bodies currently publish a consolidated, public-facing incident register.

[Half-beat]

The Information Regulator acts after the fact under POPIA, and mostly on data-privacy grounds. The State Security Agency operates in classified channels. Individual departments hold their own fragments. The Cybersecurity Hub at SITA is meant to coordinate but does not publish publicly. Parliament's oversight committees receive fragmentary briefings.

[Half-beat]

A researcher, a journalist, or a curious citizen who wants to understand the state of South African government cybersecurity has to do what I have just done for this episode: pull nine incidents from nine different public sources, cross-reference them against international reporting, and assemble a timeline by hand.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

[NARRATION — CLOSE MIC.]

That is not how a serious country tracks attacks on its own state.

[PAUSE — 3 seconds]

ACT IV — THE COMPOSITE TARGET — 13:30-15:30

[NARRATION — return to standard distance. This act is structural pattern-finding.]

Strip the nine incidents down to their shared traits and a composite portrait of the target emerges.

[PAUSE — 1 beat]

The typical target is a **national-level institution** — not provincial, not municipal. Seven of the nine incidents hit national departments, state-owned entities, or constitutional bodies. The

provincial and municipal layers barely feature in the public record, which may mean they are less attacked, or may mean they are even less likely to disclose. Both possibilities are troubling.

[Half-beat]

The typical target runs **legacy Windows infrastructure with limited segmentation**. Where technical details have surfaced — Transnet, Justice, NHLS — the same pattern repeats. Older operating systems. Flat networks. Domain controllers that, once compromised, give attackers the keys to everything.

[Half-beat]

The typical target has **outsourced significant portions of its IT operations to contractors** — SITA in some cases, private vendors in others — creating a supply-chain surface that the institution does not fully control and cannot fully defend.

[Half-beat]

The typical target has **no publicly named chief information security officer**, no public incident response plan, and no publicly stated disclosure policy. The people who would need to communicate with the public about a breach are, for the most part, anonymous to the public before the breach and during it.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

[NARRATION — CLOSE MIC.]

The composite is not flattering. A national institution, running aging infrastructure, dependent on contractors it cannot audit, with no disclosed security leadership, no disclosed plan, and a disclosure culture that defaults to silence.

[Half-beat]

That is the target profile. And it is the target profile of most of the South African state.

[PAUSE — 3 seconds]

ACT V — THE SLOW BREACH — 15:30-19:00

[SOUND DESIGN — Runtime State brand pad enters at 15:30. C minor, sustained, -28dB. Rides under this act. Same pad treatment as Episode One's Act V.]

[NARRATION — summative register.]

Nine incidents. Five years. One pattern.

[PAUSE — 1 beat]

The South African state is not being breached by sophisticated nation-state actors deploying zero-days — although some of the incidents do involve state-aligned capabilities. Most of these attacks are ordinary ransomware operations, the kind that hit municipal governments in Texas and regional hospitals in the United Kingdom every week. The attackers are not unusual. The targets are.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

The attacks keep landing because the institutions keep offering the same surface. Aging systems. Fragmented oversight. Opaque contractor relationships. And a disclosure culture that treats every breach as a reputational event to be managed rather than an operational event to be reported.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

South Africa's 2024–2028 National Security Strategy, published last year, acknowledges — in sharper language than previous versions — that cyberattacks on state information resources are increasing. That acknowledgment matters. It is the first time at the strategic level the state has been candid about the trend line.

[Half-beat]

But strategy documents do not substitute for operational transparency. And operational transparency is exactly where the current model breaks down.

[PAUSE — 2 seconds]

[NARRATION — CLOSE MIC. Close register.]

A realistic reform path would start with three moves.

[Brief pause]

One. A mandatory incident register under the State Security Agency or the Information Regulator, published quarterly, with confirmed incidents, sector, attack type, and high-level impact. No classified details. No attribution. Just the fact that the breach happened, and when, and how much service went down.

[Half-beat]

Two. A public-facing post-incident reporting standard, modelled on what the US CISA and the UK's NCSC already publish. Thirty days from breach confirmation to public technical summary. No exceptions for embarrassment.

[Half-beat]

Three. A named, publicly accountable CISO at every national department and every schedule-2 state-owned entity. Not anonymous. Not rotated every six months. Named, with a track record, answerable to Parliament.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

None of these three reforms requires new legislation. POPIA, the Cybercrimes Act, and existing parliamentary oversight mechanisms already provide the legal basis. What is missing is the political will to compel the disclosure.

[PAUSE — 3 seconds]

[Pad blooms slightly, -22dB for the landing.]

[NARRATION — full register for the landing.]

The Slow Breach is not slow because the attacks are slow. The attacks are fast. The breach is slow because the acknowledgment is slow. Because eighteen months after Transnet's ports went dark, the country was still learning what had actually happened. Because the public learned about SARB from the FBI. Because the public learned about Parliament from a press release about a YouTube channel.

[PAUSE — 2 beats]

A state that cannot tell its citizens, within a reasonable window, when it has been breached, is a state that cannot be held accountable for being breached.

[Half-beat]

And a state that cannot be held accountable for being breached will keep being breached.

[PAUSE — 4 seconds]

[Pad resolves to suspended major. Holds.]

SIGN-OFF — 19:00-19:30

[NARRATION — warmer close.]

This has been Runtime State. Episode three. *The Slow Breach — Five Years of Cyber Incidents Inside South Africa's Government*.

[Half-beat]

The full visual timeline, the sources for each of the nine incidents, and a downloadable incident register are at runtimestate.com/posts/government-cyber-breaches. Links in the show notes.

[PAUSE — 1 beat]

I'm Sethu Nguna. Thank you for listening.

[Pad fades over 5 seconds to silence.]

PRODUCTION NOTES

Total runtime target: 19 minutes 30 seconds. The dossier section (Act II) is the most rhythmically important. Each incident gets its own chime, its own date-anchor, and a closing silence of 2-3 seconds. Do not collapse the silences to save time. The cumulative weight of the list is what makes Act III's pattern-finding land.

Register shifts.

- Cold Open and the SARB dossier (Incident Three) — close mic, almost clinical
- The nine incidents generally — reportorial, date-stamped, brisker pace
- Parliament dossier (Incident Eight) — second close-mic moment, on the "communications posture" line
- Act III, Pattern Three close — close mic for "That is not how a serious country tracks attacks on its own state"
- Act IV composite close — close mic for the target-profile summation
- Act V reforms and landing — close mic, then full register for the final two lines

Sound palette (unchanged from Episode One):

- Studio room tone at -45dB under all narration
- Runtime State brand pad: cold open (00:22-00:25), Act V opening (15:30 onward)
- Dossier chime: single soft chime at -25dB at the start of each of the nine incidents
- Page-flip at -30dB between Act II and Act III only
- Deliberate silence at the close of each dossier (2-3 seconds) and after the three diagnostic close-mic lines (3 seconds each)
- No ambient field recording. No percussion. No voice stings.

Chapter markers.

00:00 Cold Open — The FBI Phones the Hawks
00:30 Act I — The Argument
02:15 Act II — The Nine Incidents
02:30 Incident 1 — Transnet (July 2021)
03:15 Incident 2 — Justice (September 2021)
04:00 Incident 3 — SARB (August 2022)
05:00 Incident 4 — SANDF (September 2023)
05:40 Incident 5 — NHLS (June 2024)
06:25 Incident 6 — DPWI (2024)
07:05 Incident 7 — SA Weather Service (2024)
07:45 Incident 8 — Parliament (March 2025)
08:30 Incident 9 — Stats SA (2025-26)
09:30 Act III — The Patterns
13:30 Act IV — The Composite Target
15:30 Act V — The Slow Breach
19:00 Sign-off

Reference listens. Same as Episode One — *Slow Burn*, *Revisionist History*, *The Trojan Horse Affair*. For the dossier rhythm specifically, listen to *Serial Season 3* episode one, where Sarah Koenig walks through a day in Cleveland's courtrooms case-by-case. The pacing of "name, date, what happened, how we found out" should feel like that — present-tense, clinical, accumulating weight through repetition rather than drama.

A note on attribution. The underlying post credits threat intelligence shared via @VECERTRadar and cites gov.za, NHLS Annual Report 2023-24, weathersa.co.za, parliament.gov.za, statssa.gov.za, IOL, Sunday Independent, resbank.co.za, Daily Maverick, ITWeb, The Record, Carnegie Endowment, and Tech Policy Press. All of these should be listed in the episode show notes.